EP-L2: Elastic Payload Storage for In-Place Writeback in GPU L2 Caches

Author information to be completed
English working draft EN-v6 — not for submission

***Abstract*—A fixed-partition L2 may copy a dirty victim into a writeback buffer even though its data do not change. Elastic Payload L2 (EP-L2) retains the victim in place, separates tag visibility from payload ownership and writeback ordering, and allocates resident/writeback roles across a shared pool. We evaluate this WB-only mechanism against a fixed-partition reference with equal payload capacity and modeled bank service. Independent intake of five complete native nonatomic workload pairs confirms removal of all resident-to-writeback copies. However, the geometric-mean execution-speed ratio is only 1.001600, with one slowdown; end-to-end performance is nearly unchanged. Three pressured workloads eliminate WB-data-full events while increasing downstream queue-admission denials. These observations motivate a controlled downstream-headroom study rather than establish its cause. The evidence covers symbolic sector versions and resource lifecycle, not numerical SASS outputs. Independent elasticity benefits, general workload speedup, and physical PPA advantages remain unestablished.**

***Index Terms*—GPU, L2 cache, writeback, tag–data decoupling, resource sharing**

I. Introduction

A dirty eviction changes a line's consumer without changing its data. Yet the fixed-partition reference studied here copies the victim from resident storage to a writeback buffer (WBUF) before reusing its slot. A source-bank read, destination-bank write, and later send read compete with demand accesses and fills. A fixed WBUF quota can also block evictions despite idle slots elsewhere. Removing this work helps execution only if progress is not limited by another resource.

EP-L2 transfers ownership instead of location. Dirty data remain in place while the incoming resident receives another eligible slot; the old tag, payload, and writeback-ordering entry retire separately. Resident lookup capacity stays fixed. Tag–data indirection and storage sharing are established ideas [1]–[4]. Our proposed contribution is an in-place dirty-writeback protocol with explicit ownership and release obligations under a fixed payload and bank-service budget.

The primary question is whether copy removal and resident/WB pooling improve useful service enough to justify control cost. Five matched workload pairs show substantial copy reduction but only a 0.160% geometric-mean speed-ratio gain. Concurrent dynamic bypass and optional TVD/RO mechanisms are outside this comparison. Strong static controls remain necessary to distinguish elasticity from the selected reference partition.

II. EP-L2 Design

A. One-Slice Organization and Comparison Boundary

The primary reference, B16 (`B16_BANKED`), partitions 1168 line-sized slots into 1024 resident, 128 bypass-return, and 16 WBUF slots. U-WB16 (`U_WB16`) permits resident and WB allocations across this physical pool. Each slot is 128 B with four 32-B sectors. Both modes provision four banks of 292 slots, at most one modeled line-sized operation per bank per physical GPU cycle, and a common 128-B copy latch outside the pool. Both also retain 128 writeback address-directory (WAD) entries and the same request-metadata limits. Sixteen is the static *data* quota, not the U-WB control limit.

Figure 1 shows the declared service model. WB-only pooling can borrow reference bypass-return slots, but concurrent dynamic bypass use is unvalidated. Idle bypass capacity therefore makes a WB-heavy static control important.

A resident tag names a payload through a slot identifier and generation. Each slot has one authoritative owner; ready/pending sector masks and pins track its consumers. The initial design preserves the resident bank class:

$$\text{bank}(p) = p \bmod 4 = \text{tag_index} \bmod 4. \tag{1}$$

A globally free slot is therefore not necessarily a legal landing for a given tag. The 1024 tags bound resident visibility; a temporarily reserved incoming landing is not an additional visible resident line.

B. Replacement as a Transaction

Before a dirty replacement commits, the controller obtains the address-ordering entry, required issue resources, and a legal landing. In B16, it reads the victim into the latch and writes WBUF before reusing the resident slot. In U-WB16, dirty line A remains in payload p as `WB_STAGED`; new resident B receives $q \neq p$. The send read and lower data carrier remain necessary in both modes.

Precheck refusals acquire no visible ownership; bank retries may retain reservations across cycles. The reserved victim, requester, and eventual native tag commit must agree. If an intervening fill changes a subsequent victim selection, the controller must preserve the original transaction or fully roll it back before preparing another. Rollback releases reservations, not bank work already performed.

The repaired release passes producer and independent directed qualification, including the tested cross-cycle boundary. Application qualification remains bounded by the native nonatomic scope below.

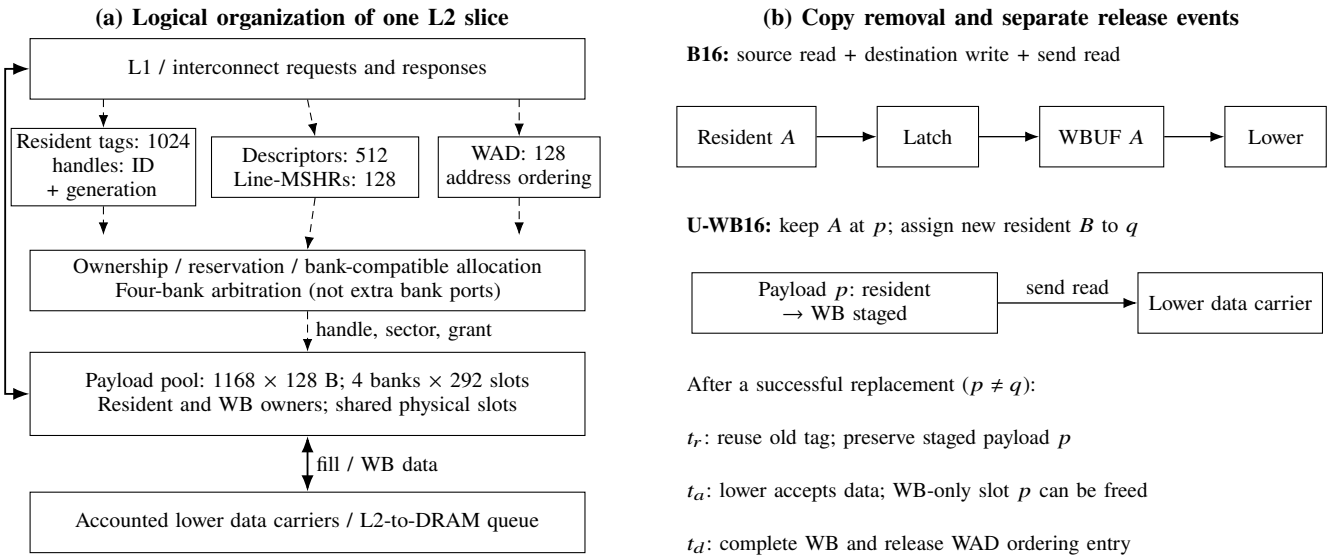


Fig. 1. Declared WB-only design, not a physical floorplan or a measured cycle schedule. Dashed links denote control dependencies; solid links denote data movement. B16 uses fixed 1024/128/16 role quotas over the same banks; U-WB16 allows resident/WB allocation across those slots. Concurrent dynamic bypass service is not established. Both retain a 128-B copy latch outside the pool. Optional TVD/RO consumers are not drawn as extra data arrays.

C. Separate Release Events

At committed replacement time t_r, the old tag can be reused. Payload p remains protected until actual downstream data acceptance t_a. The WAD retains same-address ordering until writeback completion t_d. A software queue pointer alone does not constitute a data handoff: a separately accounted lower carrier must own the dirty data before local staging is released. A late event for A uses its own handle/transaction identity, not the tag now naming B.

For tracked reads, requester descriptors and payload pins remain live until response-queue acceptance or internal consumption. Line-MSHR retirement and pending-sector completion are checked separately. Neither event releases a WB address-ordering obligation. A read of one ready sector does not imply that an entire line is ready. Atomic and ordinary requests sharing a line additionally require sector-appropriate dirty and version handling.

Local drain progress requires both eventual lower service and a bank retry that remains identifiable until completion or explicit cancellation. An oldest-selected grant alone cannot guarantee progress if its requester changes identity or stops retrying. Whole-GPU deadlock freedom is not established by these local requirements.

D. Implementation Cost and Separate Extensions

Primary payload storage is 146 KiB/slice, or 9.125 MiB over 64 slices; common latches add 8 KiB/chip. A slot index requires $P = 11$ bits. Explicit tag handles occupy $1024(P+G)$ bits for generation width G; up to 128 WB handles require $128(P+G)$ bits plus state and transaction binding. These are gross representations, not measured incremental area: the reference already includes some common fields.

Incremental cost includes handle selection, owner/generation checks, bank-compatible allocation, arbitration, and rollback. Queue depths, generation/pin bounds, pipeline stages, SRAM ports, and the carrier after t_a need concrete mappings. Symbolic versions are verification state, not payload RAM. Equal capacity/throughput does not prove equal hit latency, area, clock, or energy. No RTL synthesis, STA, or power measurement is available.

TVD retains displaced payloads within a shared 128-entry WAD/TVD budget. RO controls pending-tag detachment and Line-MSHR bypass under a whole-commandlist read-only oracle. Both are OFF here. TVD lacks official integrated qualification; RO has isolated source-bound C++ checks, but its 19 production obligations and independent scientific qualification remain pending. Neither has accepted application results or an extra data/descriptor pool.

III. Evaluation Methodology

A. Matched Inputs and Declared Machine

We use the Accel-Sim SASS flow and GPGPU-Sim performance-model lineage [5], [6]. Their published validation does not validate this modified L2. B16 and U-WB16 must execute with the same independently qualified binary, complete trace input, non-mode settings, timing scope, and termination rules. Table I records the current ordered research configuration, including the modified L2; it is not a reconstruction of undocumented commercial-cache internals.

The fixed development set is convolutionSeparable, FWT_7_21, cfd_097k, vectorAdd_4M, and SAD. Accepted manifests bind each complete commandlist, input size, and trace body; workload names alone are insufficient. SAD is the predeclared negative control. All five pairs, including slowdowns, enter the geometric mean. This development set does not establish holdout or general GPU coverage.

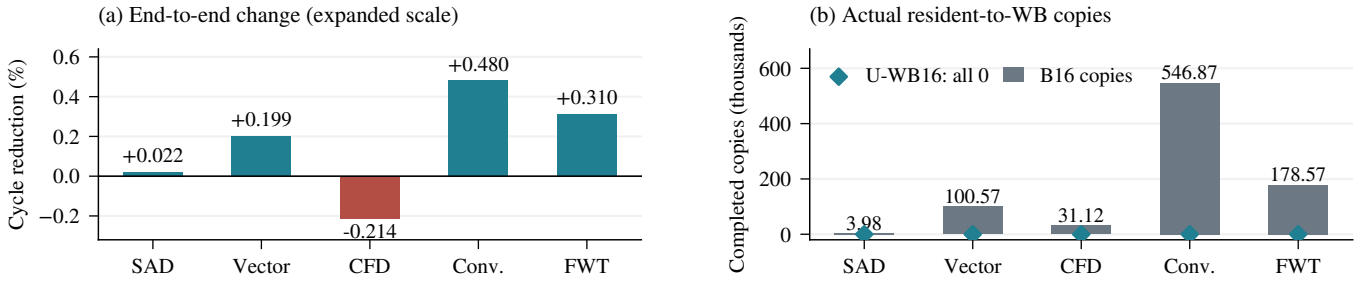


Fig. 2. Five independently received, currently accepted native pairs. (a) Cycle reduction $100(C_B - C_U)/C_B$, on an expanded scale with zero denoting B16; CFD regression is retained. The speed-ratio geomean is 1.001600, not the mean of these percentages. (b) Actual completed 128-B copies; U-WB16 is zero in every pair. Vector, Conv., and FWT denote vectorAdd_4M, convolutionSeparable, and FWT_7_21. No error bars or significance claim.

TABLE I
DECLARED MATCHED CONFIGURATION. L2 CAPACITIES ARE PER SLICE.

Resource	Setting
Compute / clock domains	80 SMs; core/ICNT/L2: 1132 MHz; DRAM: 850 MHz
L1 (fixed)	64 KiB/SM; 4 banks; 20-cycle setting
L2 tags / data	1024 tags; 1168 slots, 146 KiB
Line / sectors / banks	128 B / 4 × 32 B / 4 × 292 slots
Service / common latch	1 op/bank/physical cycle / 128 B
Descriptors / Line-MSHRs	512 / 128; 32 requesters/address
WAD / lower queue	128 / 128 entries
Chip / memory channels	64 slices / 32 channels
L2 ROP delay	160-cycle model setting
DRAM scheduler / return	128 / 192 entries per channel
WBUF8 (not evaluated)	1160 slots, 145 KiB; 4 × 290 slots

B. Correctness Before Performance

The repaired producer and its independent replay each pass 31 directed invocations, and Lane5 accepts the complete eleven-gate protocol. Per-spec complete-content proofs restrict application qualification to native nonatomic inputs. New results remain bound to the exact source, binary, configurations, and input content.

Qualification covers host-prefill identity, physical-cycle grants, generation reuse, partial/out-of-order sectors, response backpressure, and separate WB acceptance/completion. Native tag time may include a host-copy offset; bank service must use the physical clock. Nonatomic results do not qualify mixed atomic workloads.

SASS traces do not supply complete numerical payloads. The supported checks concern ownership, symbolic sector versions, requester/transaction identity, and resource drain; they are not full numerical application verification. The independent paper intake rehashes full native trace bodies, executable, ordered configurations, and raw logs, reparses all 64 slice terminals with the producing parser, and checks the current withdrawal authority. Legacy zero-mask records remain in the original inputs under a source-bound native-byte semantic proof; no rows are removed. Historical PASS cannot override a later scientific withdrawal.

IV. Results and Causal Analysis

A. Performance and Internal Movement

All five predeclared pairs pass independent paper intake against current Lane5 V2 generation 8. Each pair has equal instruction counts and matched full input/termination scope. Figure 2(a) reports the complete set: SAD is almost tied; Vector, Convolution, and FWT reduce cycles by 0.199%, 0.480%, and 0.310%, while CFD increases cycles by 0.214%. The geometric mean of C_B/C_U is 1.001600, or a 0.160% speed-ratio gain. These deterministic paired observations establish neither statistical significance nor general GPU speedup. Exact paired cycles and source/configuration/input/raw identities accompany the artifact tables.

Figure 2(b) shows removal of every measured resident-to-WB copy. A committed non-rolled-back B16 writeback uses two copy operations and one send read; U-WB16 retains the send read. This local operation saving is not a speedup model. Actual WB counts also change: CFD completes 31,123/31,063 WBs and FWT 178,569/178,585 for B16/U-WB16. Consequently, the run-level logical-operation difference need not equal twice either mode's WB count. Artifact tables preserve actual WB/send-read and DRAM-byte totals.

B. Local Pressure and Downstream Service

Vector, Convolution, and FWT record 440,161, 845,097, and 890,294 B16 WB-data-full events; U-WB16 records zero. Figure 3(b) shows less modeled bank work and lower aggregate conflict waits. Successful grants are actual model-service observations, not estimates obtained by multiplying copies. At drained termination, their equality to logical operations implies neither elapsed-time nor RTL timing/energy savings.

For the same three workloads, L2-to-DRAM full-block attempts rise from 1.104M to 1.764M, 0.218M to 1.132M, and 0.013M to 0.968M. This is consistent with pressure moving downstream after local staging relief. It does not independently identify the limiting queue or DRAM service. Denials may repeat for one frontend head and overlap other blockers. From final cumulative observations of all 32 channels, the modeled issued-byte/atom-cycle fractions are 64.5/64.8% for Convolution and 14.1/14.1% for FWT. Even frequent

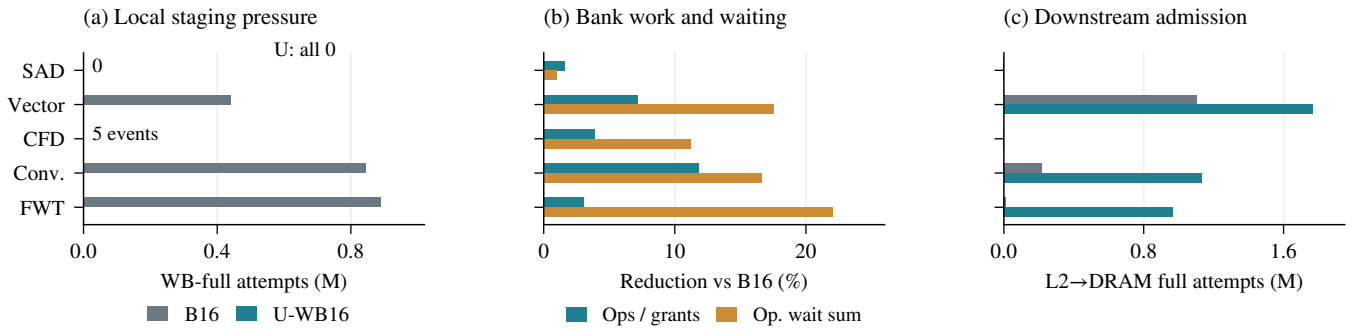


Fig. 3. Application-cumulative pressure and service observations. (a) WB-data-full refusal attempts; CFD's small B16 count is labeled explicitly. (b) Separate relative reductions in logical work/successful modeled bank grants and in summed per-operation conflict waits. Logical operations and grants coincide at drain in these runs, but are independently checked counters. (c) Frontend attempts denied when the L2-to-DRAM queue is full. M denotes 10^6. Attempt counts and operation-wait sums are not elapsed GPU cycles or unique transactions; reductions and increases do not establish causality.

Equal-capacity static control

MEASUREMENTS PENDING

Not executed or qualified. Same 1168 slots, different fixed role quotas; WBUF8 is not a substitute.

Fig. 4. Remaining control gap. A qualified fixed-total static comparison is needed to isolate elasticity from the selected split. No results are plotted.

queue denials therefore do not prove global DRAM-bandwidth saturation. Kernel-boundary cumulative snapshots are not summed.

CFD is a useful counterexample: despite removing copies and lowering bank waits from 102,546 to 91,029, U-WB16 takes 169 more cycles. WAD-hazard events increase from 9,841 to 13,400, WB counts differ, and successful DRAM writes change from 3,983,744 to 3,976,064 B. These correlated changes motivate ordering/service diagnosis; they do not identify a unique cause. SAD has no observed WB-data-full pressure and differs by only 24 cycles. Neither case is discarded.

C. Causal Limits and Next Test

B16 versus U-WB16 combines copy removal and cross-role allocation. The counters demonstrate neither an independent capacity-performance benefit nor the best static partition. The proposed 1024/112/32 resident/bypass/WB control preserves 1168 slots, but requires new quota support and independent qualification; merely selecting WBUF32 in the frozen interface changes the budget. WBUF8 instead uses 1160 slots and is not this control.

The immediate proposed diagnostic is a matched B16/U-WB16 × original/larger L2-to-DRAM-queue comparison for Convolution and FWT, with CFD retained as an ordering counterexample. It needs separate configuration/resource approval and qualification before execution. Increased headroom changes buffering, not DRAM bandwidth; the speed-ratio interaction must be considered alongside queue occupancy, scheduler service, WAD pressure, and actual bytes. Ideal WB/metadata/read-hit matrices are also unqualified for this production binary. The present WB-only application-speedup case is weak; further experiments should test this ambiguity rather than seek more favorable inputs.

V. Related Work and Scope

V-Way decouples placement [1]; Tag-Split Cache changes storage granularity while retaining coarse requests [7]. EP-L2 fixes resident tags and sectors. Gebhart *et al.* repartition SM-local storage at kernel boundaries using a write-through cache [2].

In-cache MSHRs reuse storage for pending-load information [3]; MiCache shares FPGA storage between cache lines and MSHR subentries [4]; DL-MSHR adapts linked miss slots that can also hold write data [8]. Our focus is existing dirty data remaining in place while tag visibility and WB ordering retire separately. MRPB reorders/bypasses GPU L1 requests [9], and victim caching retains displaced lines [10]. TVD/RO combinations require separate evaluation; additive benefits are not assumed.

VI. Conclusion

EP-L2 separates resident-tag visibility, dirty-payload ownership, and writeback ordering to eliminate resident-to-WB relocation under a fixed payload and bank-service budget. Five independently received native nonatomic pairs remove all measured copies but deliver only a 1.001600 geometric-mean speed ratio, including a CFD slowdown. Local staging relief coincides with more downstream admission denials in three workloads; a controlled service study is required to resolve causality. Independent elasticity benefits and physical area, timing, and power advantages remain unproven.

References

[1] M. K. Qureshi, D. Thompson, and Y. N. Patt, "The V-Way cache: Demand-based associativity via global replacement," in *Proceedings of the 32nd Annual International Symposium on Computer Architecture (ISCA)*, 2005, pp. 544–555.

[2] M. Gebhart, S. W. Keckler, B. Khailany, R. Krashinsky, and W. J. Dally, "Unifying primary cache, scratch, and register file memories in a throughput processor," in *Proceedings of the 45th Annual IEEE/ACM International Symposium on Microarchitecture (MICRO)*, 2012, pp. 96–106.

[3] K. I. Farkas and N. P. Jouppi, "Complexity/performance tradeoffs with non-blocking loads," Digital Equipment Corporation, Western Research Laboratory, Research Report 94/3, Mar. 1994.

[4] S. Xu, S. Lu, Z. Shao, X. Liao, and H. Jin, "MiCache: An MSHR-inclusive non-blocking cache design for FPGAs," in *Proceedings of the 2024 ACM/SIGDA International Symposium on Field Programmable Gate Arrays (FPGA)*, 2024, pp. 22–32.

[5] M. Khairy, Z. Shen, T. M. Aamodt, and T. G. Rogers, "Accel-Sim: An extensible simulation framework for validated GPU modeling," in *Proceedings of the 47th Annual International Symposium on Computer Architecture (ISCA)*, 2020, pp. 473–486.

[6] A. Bakhoda, G. L. Yuan, W. W. L. Fung, H. Wong, and T. M. Aamodt, "Analyzing CUDA workloads using a detailed GPU simulator," in *Proceedings of the IEEE International Symposium on Performance Analysis of Systems and Software (ISPASS)*, 2009, pp. 163–174.

[7] L. Li, A. B. Hayes, S. L. Song, and E. Z. Zhang, "Tag-split cache for efficient GPGPU cache utilization," in *Proceedings of the 2016 International Conference on Supercomputing (ICS)*, 2016, pp. 43:1–43:12.

[8] Y. Gu and L. Chen, "Dynamically linked MSHRs for adaptive miss handling in GPUs," in *Proceedings of the International Conference on Supercomputing (ICS)*, 2019, pp. 510–521.

[9] W. Jia, K. A. Shaw, and M. Martonosi, "MRPB: Memory request prioritization for massively parallel processors," in *Proceedings of the 20th IEEE International Symposium on High Performance Computer Architecture (HPCA)*, 2014, pp. 272–283.

[10] N. P. Jouppi, "Improving direct-mapped cache performance by the addition of a small fully-associative cache and prefetch buffers," in *Proceedings of the 17th Annual International Symposium on Computer Architecture (ISCA)*, 1990, pp. 364–373.